After a lifetime of human alliance, a creature whose numbers used to be in the hundreds of thousands for each regional warlord was estimated at fewer than 35,000 in the wild. Modern India's elephants have been hunted for sport, killed out of fear, and suffered dwindling numbers due to loss of natural habitat. They are listed as a formally endangered species by the International Union for Conservation of Nature, but the future isn't necessarily so dark for these precious creatures. In 1992, the Indian government's Ministry of Environment and Forests launched Project Elephant, a strategy to protect elephants and their habitats, confront the issues between human communities and elephants, and look toward the welfare of domesticated elephants.

Elephants aren't the only India animal facing extinction. They are joined by their massive feline cohabitators, the Bengal tigers, on the IUCN endangered species list. Revered for its size, power, and beautiful orange and black-striped coat, the Bengal tiger is sadly down to about 2,500 individuals in the wilds of India, though it is officially the National Animal of India. Tiger numbers have diminished immensely in just the last few centuries, mostly due to big game hunting. Preserved hides of these tigers were prized by many British colonialists who lived in India during the Raj, and the heads of these hunted cats are still considered wonderful trophies for some sports hunters.

Big game hunting by no means began with the British, of course. The industry really became big business in India when the 16th century Mughal Emperor Jalal-ud-din Muhammad Akbar arranged sport hunting safaris for himself and important visiting dignitaries. From that time, the country's aristocrats—be they Mongol, Turkic, Afghan, or otherwise—spent their leisure time on horseback or astride massive elephants, searching for the most dangerous predators of the forests and grasslands to shoot and kill. Tigers were the most passionately hunted.

Also known as the Royal Bengal, these giant cats naturally inhabit the forests, grasslands, and mangroves of India, hunting deer, sambars, nilgais, buffalos, and gaurs at night and sleeping most of the hot day away. They were revered—just as Indian elephants were—in ancient communities of the Indus River Valley. The Pashupati seal of the Indus Valley Civilization bears the likeness of this large-eyed, wide-faced cat, and in Vedic and Hindu mythology, the tiger is symbolic of power. Even the Goddess Durga